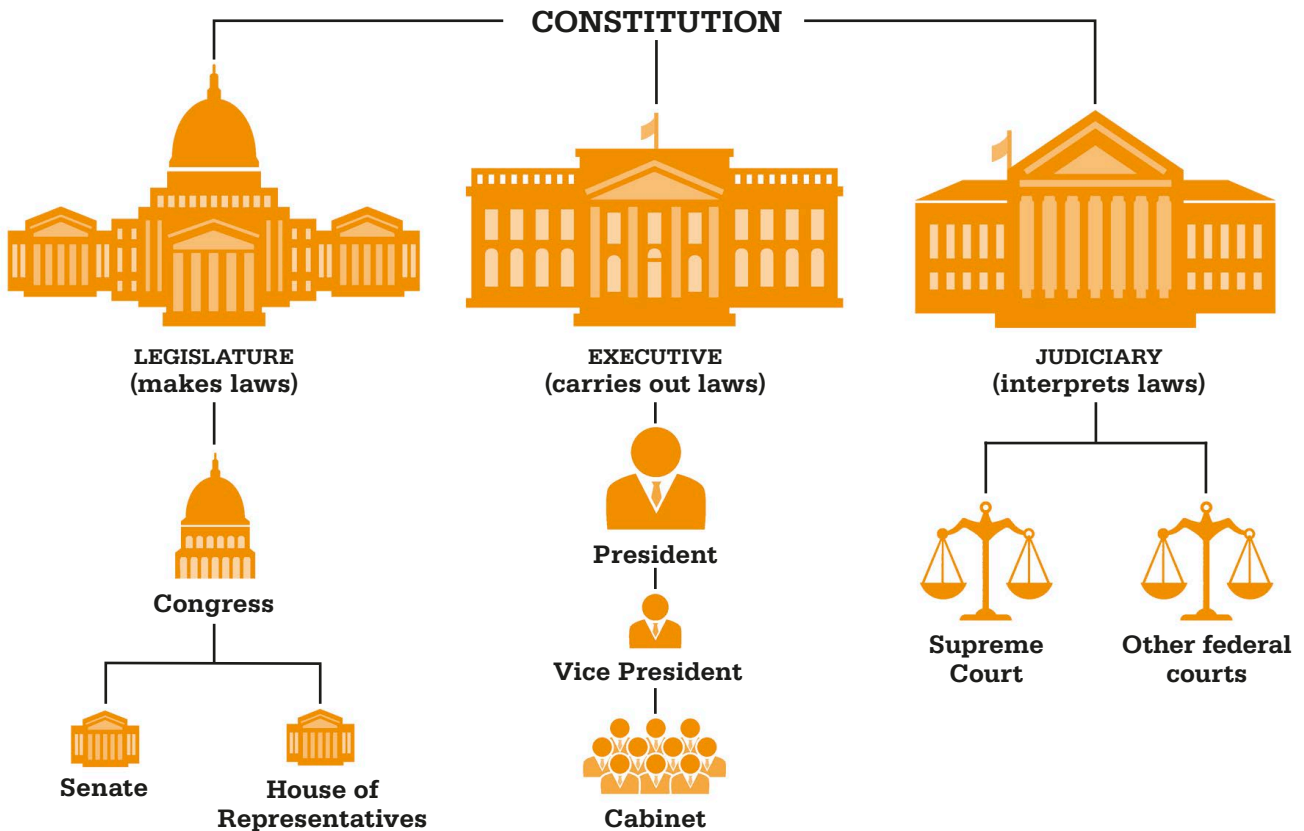


The three branches of the US government



The US Constitution separated the powers of government into three branches: the legislature, the executive, and the judiciary. The legislature makes laws; the executive enacts

them; and the judiciary interprets them and punishes lawbreakers. The divisions prevent any one branch from gaining too much power, as the other two can act as a brake.

president should be elected indirectly by “electors” chosen by each state—the Electoral College. States have the same number of electors as they do members in the two chambers of Congress.

With all issues resolved and set down, the Committee of Style, led by James Madison, finally produced the first draft of the Constitution.

Separation of powers

The Constitution is concise—just over 4,000 words long. Yet it provided the basis for a complex machinery of government that now employs

millions of people. Much of its complexity stems from the desire of those early delegates to separate the branches of government, limiting the authority of each with a system of checks and balances designed to avoid the abuse of power. They had fought the Revolutionary War to challenge the tyranny of centralized power, so they were naturally nervous about a new central government. In fact, many states only agreed to ratify the Constitution if they could be sure they would have some guarantee of protection against the new government’s power.

As a result of these concerns, the US government is divided horizontally between lawmakers (the legislative body: Congress), law enactors (the executive: the office of the president), and law interpreters (the judiciary: the Supreme Court) and also vertically between federal, state, and local governments.

Signed and ratified

The draft Constitution (written out by clerk Jacob Shallus for a fee of \$30) was finally presented to the delegates in September 1787.